

VANGUARD COMICS PRESENTS

VOL.

01

TENSION CRAFT

CELL
07
RENN

TENSION-CRAFT
CLASS 3 OFFENDER



VANGUARD
DISCIPLINE. ORDER. PURPOSE.



ID-07-RENN-TC

\$4.99 US
RATED T+

VANGUARDCOMICS.COM



RENN

SOME DOORS
SHOULDN'T
BE CLOSED.

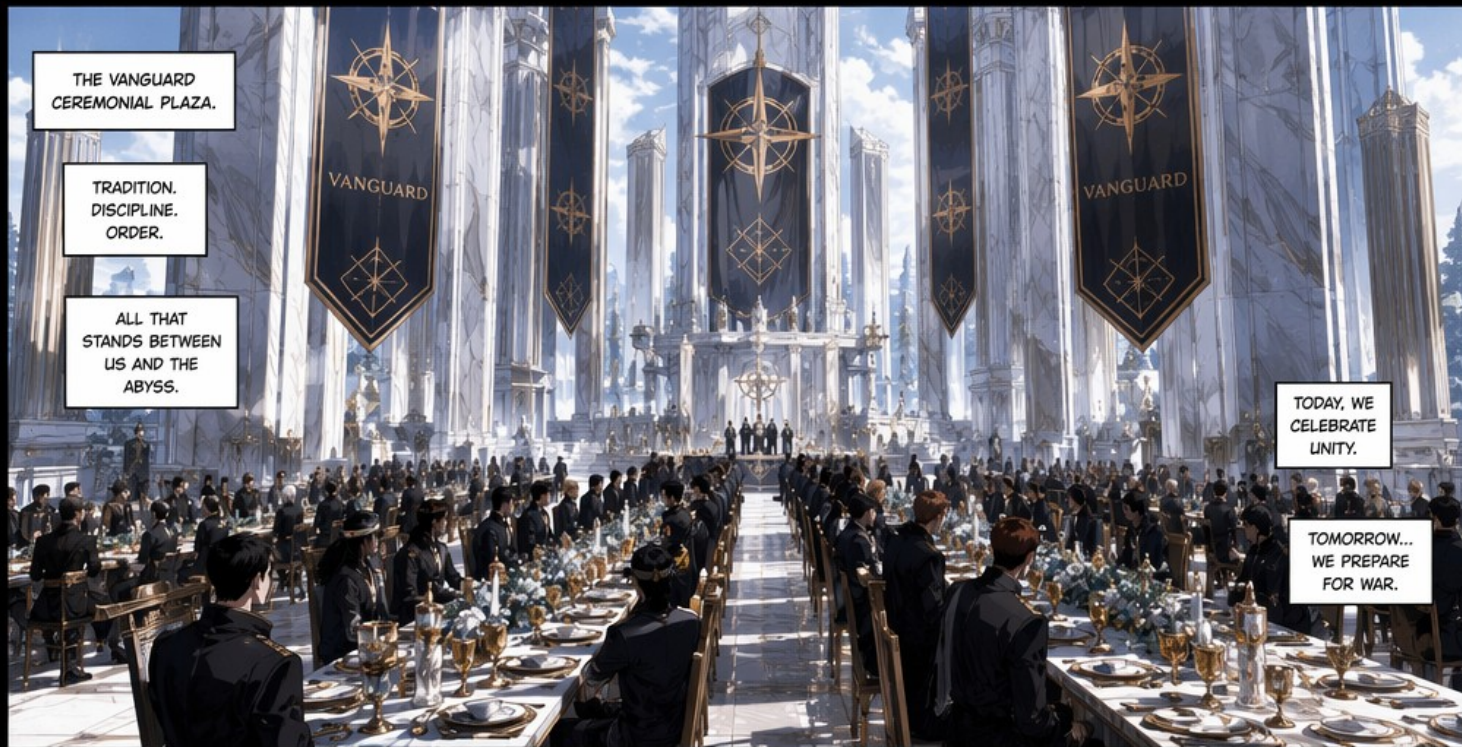


VANGUARD
MAX-SEC PROTOCOL

WARNING

TENSION-CRAFT
CONTAINMENT DOOR
STAND CLEAR

警告
テンションクラフト
隔壁ドア
近づくな



THE VANGUARD
CEREMONIAL PLAZA.

TRADITION.
DISCIPLINE.
ORDER.

ALL THAT
STANDS BETWEEN
US AND THE
ABYSS.

TODAY, WE
CELEBRATE
UNITY.

TOMORROW...
WE PREPARE
FOR WAR.



SLOANE.

ANCHORITE CADET.
STRIPPED OF
RANK.

NOT OF
PURPOSE.

RENN.

TENSION-CRAFT
JUNKER.
ONE EYE TO
THE SKY.
ONE ARM TO
REMEMBER IT
BY.

LADY
VORLENE.

STEADFAST
GUIDE.

SHARP EYE.

SHARPER
EXPECTATIONS.

HIGH MARSHAL
CAELAN VORL.

SWORD OF THE
VANGUARD.

HONOR MADE
MANIFEST.



EVERYONE
LOOKS SO
FANCY.

LIKE THEY'RE
WAITING FOR
A MIRACLE.

WE'RE
NOT HERE
FOR MIRACLES.

WE'RE HERE
BECAUSE THEY
RAN OUT OF
OPTIONS.

BE MINDFUL
OF YOUR PLACE,
BOTH OF YOU.

THE VANGUARD
WATCHES.

ALWAYS.



BEHAVIOR TODAY.

SURVIVAL
TOMORROW.

The Anchorite Vanguard
is not a family.

It is an institution.
It does not forgive.
It does not forget.

And it does not
permit its cadets
to choose their
own path.

Sloane.
Sixteen years old.

Cadet of House Aurelian.
Stripped of rank.
Stripped of future.

She was taught
obedience.

Today,
she chooses
something else.

KRRRCH

Her hands tremble.
Not from fear.

From refusing to
break.

They taught her
to kneel.

But no one ever
taught her to
betray herself.

Let them watch.

Let them remember
this moment—

The moment a cadet
stopped being
what they made her.

VANGUARD
FOUNDATION DAY.

A CEREMONY OF HONOR.
A LIE DRAPED IN SILK
AND TRADITION.

THE OUTLAW
BARGAIN IS
NOT JUST!

THE MEDICAL
BARGAIN IS
NOT MERCY!

THEY ARE
CHAINS—
AND WE
ARE NOT
THINGS TO BE
TRADED!

YOU DRESS IT
IN LAW. IN FAITH.
IN NECESSITY.

BUT AT ITS CORE—
IT IS STILL THE
SAME OLD
BARGAIN.

POWER IN EXCHANGE
FOR OUR FREEDOM.
SECURITY IN EXCHANGE
FOR OUR SOULS.

I REJECT IT.

I STAND
HERE TODAY.

NOT AS THEIR
WEAPON.

NOT AS THEIR
SACRIFICE.

BUT AS
MYSELF.

AND I WILL
NOT BE
BOUGHT.

CLATTER

I WOULD
RATHER STAND
ALONE IN TRUTH...

...THAN KNEEL
AMONG THIEVES
IN GOLD.



HOUSE SLOANE
HAS SERVED THIS CITY
FOR GENERATIONS.

WE BUILT ITS BRIDGES.
WE HELD ITS WALLS.
WE GAVE OUR BLOOD
TO KEEP THE PEACE.

AND YET, STILL,
SOME FORGET THEIR
PLACE.

SO LET IT BE
KNOWN—

THE TENSION-CRAFT
REBELLION IS NOT
A CRY FOR FREEDOM.

IT IS AN AFFRONT.

AND IT WILL BE
ANSWERED.

WE WILL
ROOT IT OUT.



STAND.

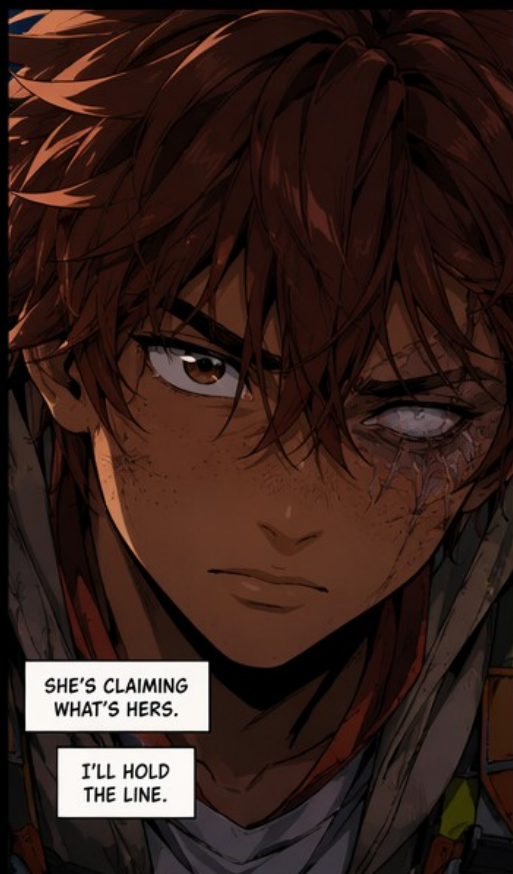
SHE FIGHTS
SO WE CAN STAND.

I SHOULD
STAND.



BUT THIS IS
HER MOMENT.

NOT MINE.



SHE'S CLAIMING
WHAT'S HERS.

I'LL HOLD
THE LINE.



HOUSE SLOANE
WILL NOT BE CHALLENGED.

NOT BY TRAITORS.

NOT BY THIEVES.

AND NOT BY
TENSION-CRAFT
DOGS.



I'LL HOLD FOR HER.
UNTIL I CAN PULL BACK.



LADIES AND GENTLEMEN
OF THE VANGUARD...

I REGRET TO INFORM YOU
THAT OUR SITUATION IS FAR
MORE DIRE THAN ANY OF US
WISHED TO BELIEVE.

?!



THE SECOND
PULL...

IT IS ALREADY
UPON US.



AND OUR DEFENSES—
OUR ZENITH—

—ARE
FAILING.



THE ZENITH WAS
DESIGNED TO WITHSTAND
EXTERNAL THREATS.

BUT THE SECOND PULL
IS NOT AN EXTERNAL
THREAT.

IT IS A FUNDAMENTAL
FORCE. IT **WARPS**
REALITY ITSELF.



OUR CALCULATIONS...
WE WERE WRONG.

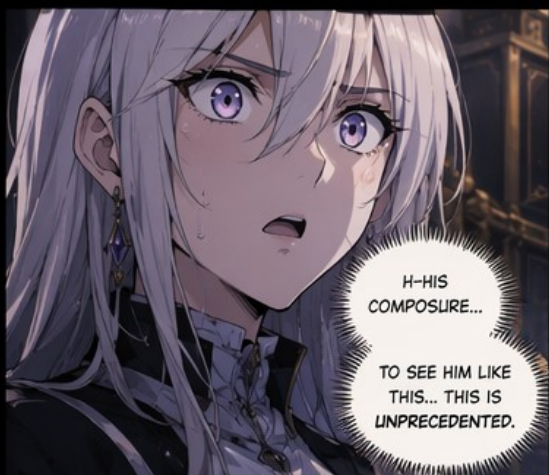
THE STABILIZING
HARMONICS CAN NO
LONGER COMPENSATE.

MURMUR

MURMUR

BREACHES ARE
APPEARING—NOT JUST
AT THE PERIMETER,
BUT **WITHIN.**

TIME IS RUNNING OUT.



H-HIS
COMPOSURE...

TO SEE HIM LIKE
THIS... THIS IS
UNPRECEDENTED.



WE NEED A SOLUTION.

AND WE NEED IT
NOW.

OR THE ZENITH—
OUR HOME, OUR PEOPLE—
WILL BE LOST TO THE
PULL **FOREVER.**

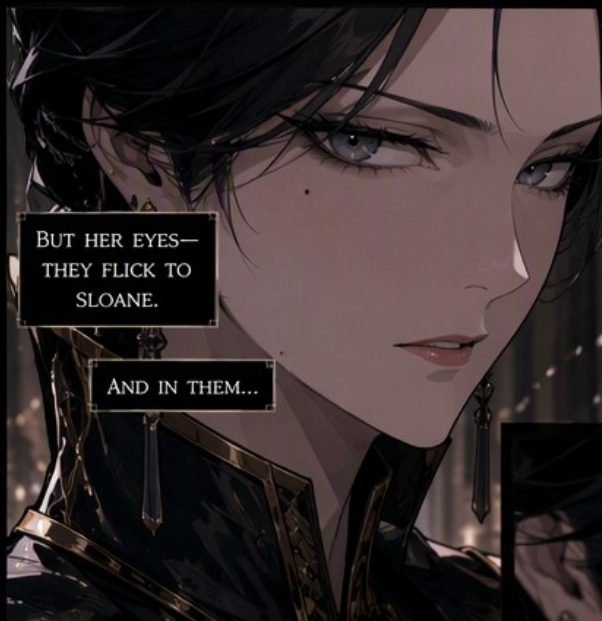


LADY
ALERIA VESTER
HOUSE VESTER
FIRST SPEAR
OF THE VANGUARD

SHE DOES
NOT RAISE
HER VOICE.

SHE DOES NOT
NEED TO.

HER SILENCE IS DISCIPLINE.
HIS BREAKING IS FAILURE.



BUT HER EYES—
THEY FLICK TO
SLOANE.

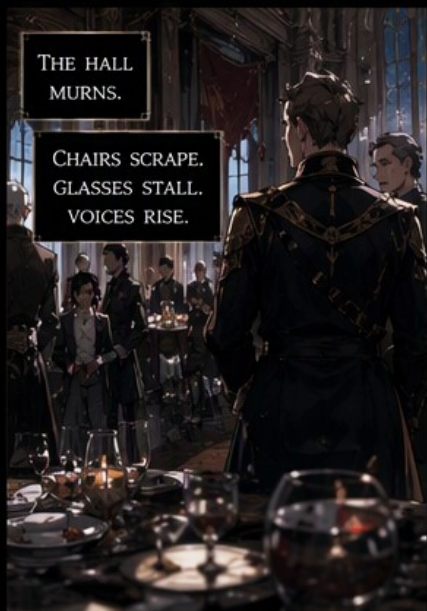
AND IN THEM...



—THERE IS
SOMETHING
BETWEEN
DISAPPOINTMENT...

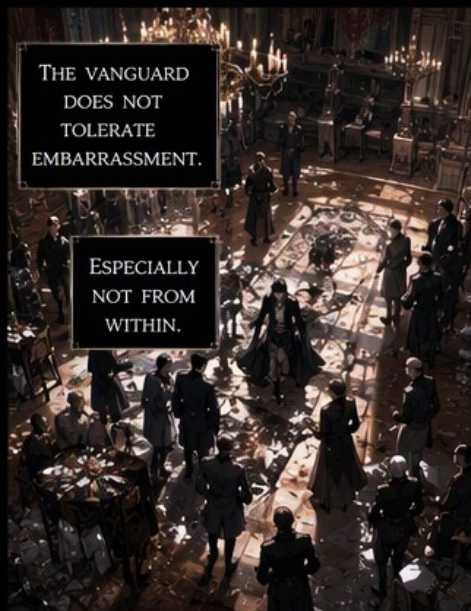


...AND
BURIED
HURT.



THE HALL
MURNS.

CHAIRS SCRAPE.
GLASSES STALL.
VOICES RISE.



THE VANGUARD
DOES NOT
TOLERATE
EMBARRASSMENT.

ESPECIALLY
NOT FROM
WITHIN.



HONOR IS
A SPEAR.

ONCE SHATTERED,
IT CAN ONLY BE
RECLAIMED IN BLOOD.



SLOANE.

YOU SERVED
WITH DISTINCTION.
YOUR PATH NEED NOT
END IN DISGRACE.

RETURN TO
THE VANGUARD.
ACCEPT MY PROTECTION.
I WILL SEE TO YOUR
REINSTATEMENT.

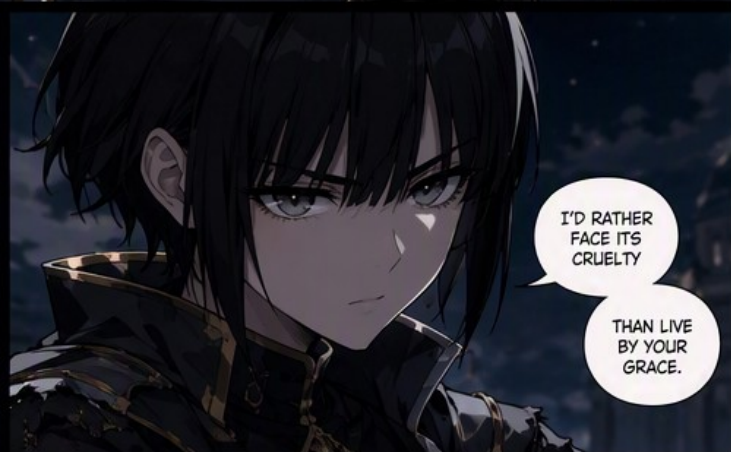
I DON'T
NEED YOUR
PROTECTION.



YOU DO
NOT NEED.

BUT YOU
WOULD BE WISE
TO ACCEPT.

THE WORLD IS
NOT AS FORGIVING
AS I AM.



I'D RATHER
FACE ITS
CRUELTY

THAN LIVE
BY YOUR
GRACE.



PRIDE IS
A DANGEROUS
COMPANION,

ESPECIALLY
FOR ONE SO
YOUNG.



BETTER PRIDE

THAN
OBEDIENCE.



VERY WELL.

SHOULD YOU
CHANGE YOUR MIND,
THE DOORS OF THE
VANGUARD WILL
REMAIN OPEN.

AND SHOULD
YOU CHANGE
YOUR MIND...

LEAVE THEM
SHUT.

LORD-WARDEN VALERIUS.
ANCHORITE VANGUARD.



ANCHORITE VANGUARD
CITADEL SPIRE

THIRD BALCONY
OVERLOOKING THE LOWER PLAZA



LORD-WARDEN
VALERIUS.

YOU WISHED
TO SPEAK
WITH ME.



CADET SLOANE.

YOUR RECORD
IS EXEMPLARY,
DESPITE...
CIRCUMSTANCES.

THE VANGUARD
NEEDS DISCIPLINED
MINDS UNTAINTED
BY DOUBT.

I WOULD
OFFER YOU
A PLACE AMONG
OUR OFFICERS.



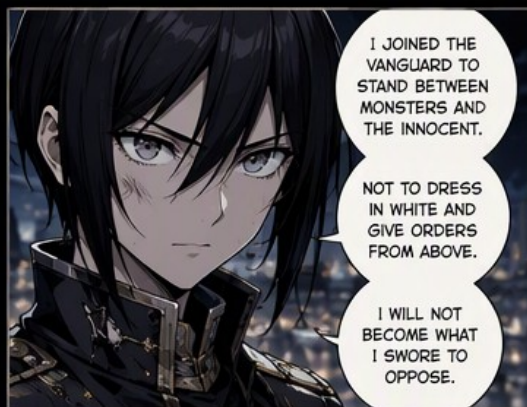
I APPRECIATE
THE OFFER,
LORD-WARDEN.

I WILL NOT
ACCEPT IT.



IS THAT
SO.

MAY I ASK
WHY?



I JOINED THE
VANGUARD TO
STAND BETWEEN
MONSTERS AND
THE INNOCENT.

NOT TO DRESS
IN WHITE AND
GIVE ORDERS
FROM ABOVE.

I WILL NOT
BECOME WHAT
I SWORE TO
OPPOSE.



...



WITH RESPECT,
MY LORD...

I HAVE
NO INTENTION
OF CLIMBING
HIGHER.

I HAVE WORK
TO DO WHERE
I STAND.

GOOD NIGHT.

HMM.

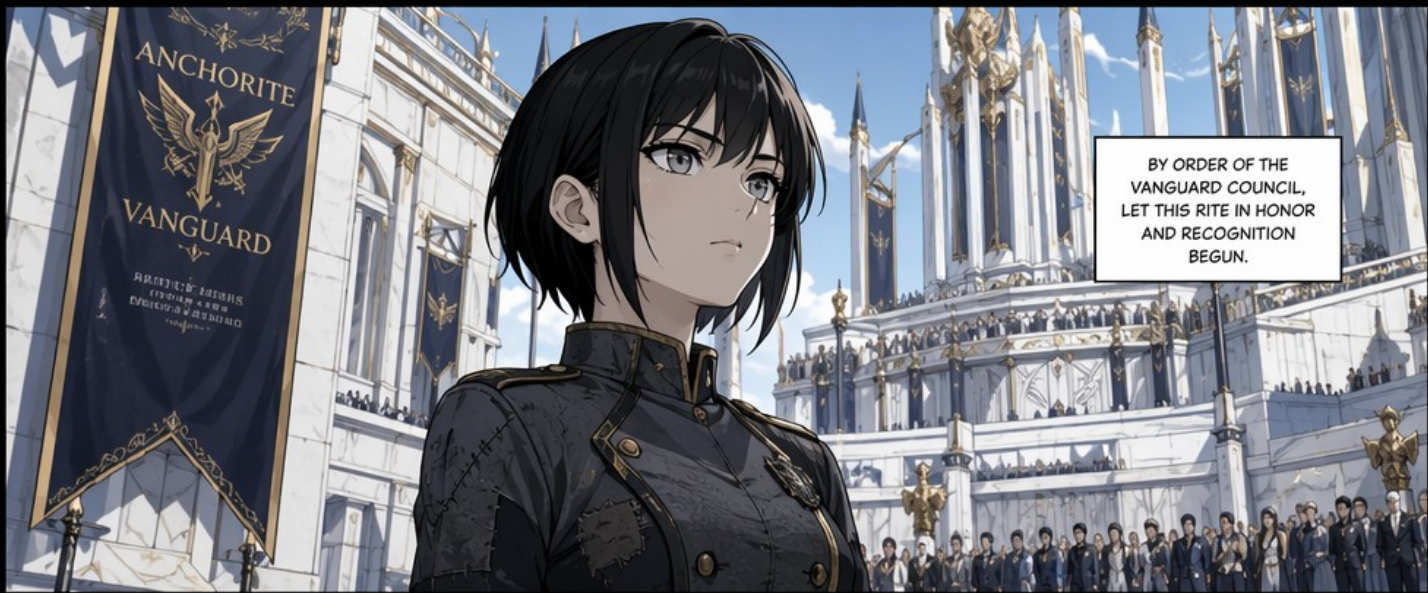
SO THAT IS
HOW SHE TRULY
SEES THE WORLD.

A PITY.

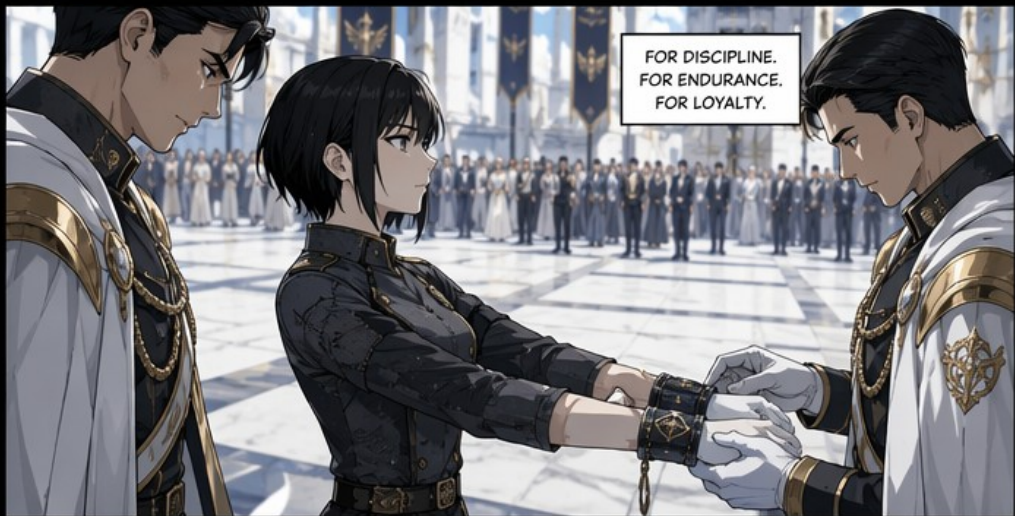
...YET I CANNOT
SAY I DID NOT
EXPECT AS MUCH.



SLOANE
ANCHORITE VANGUARD CADET



BY ORDER OF THE
VANGUARD COUNCIL,
LET THIS RITE IN HONOR
AND RECOGNITION
BEGIN.



FOR DISCIPLINE.
FOR ENDURANCE.
FOR LOYALTY.

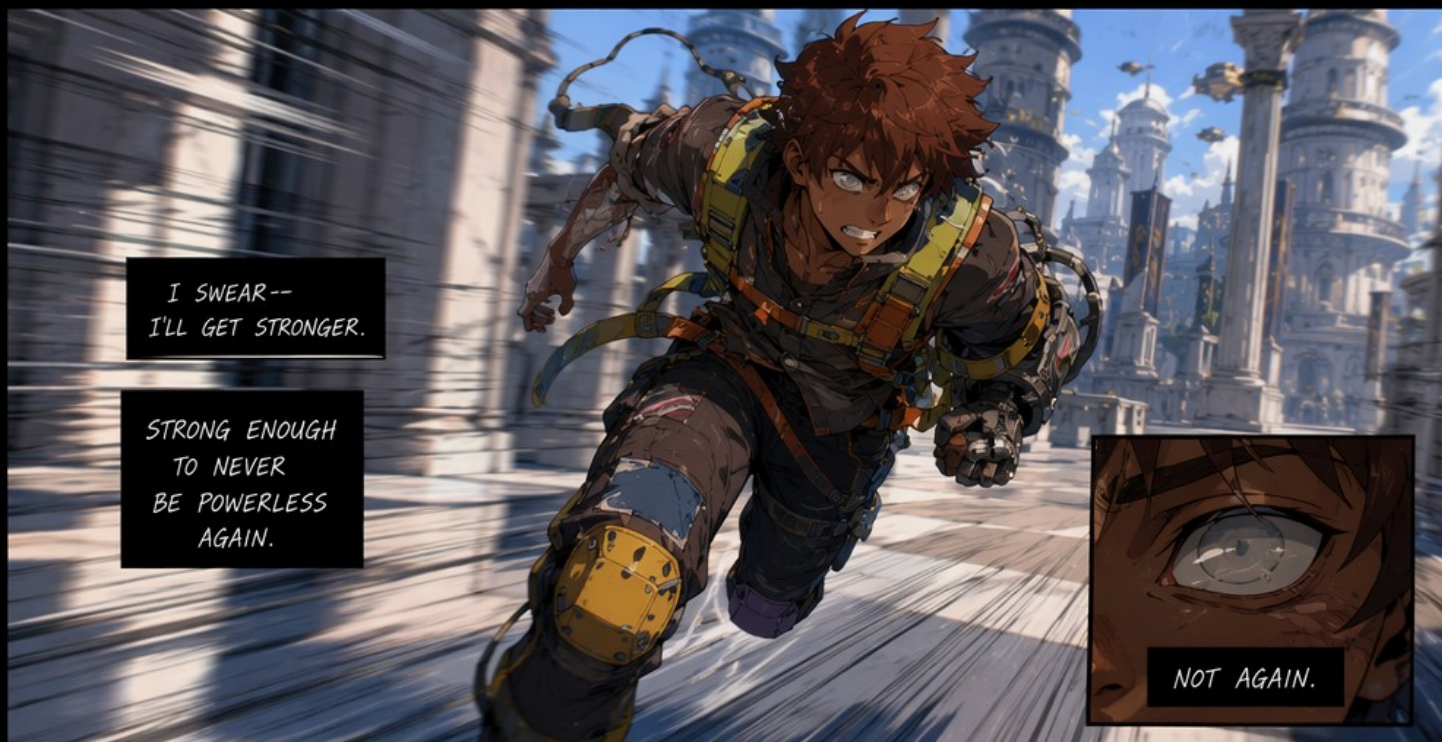
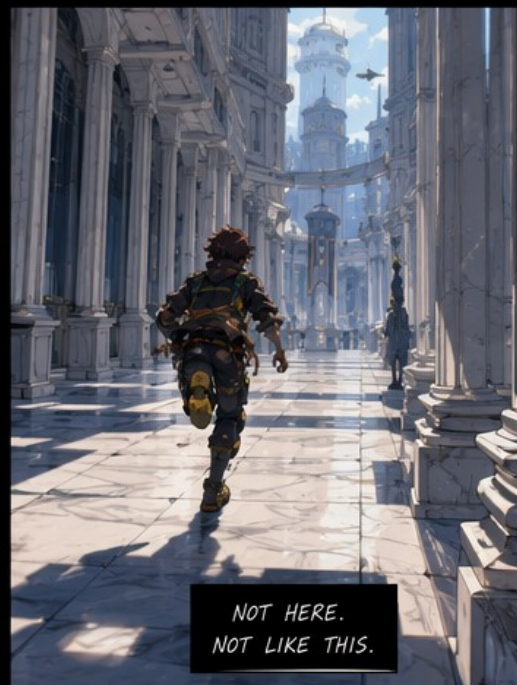
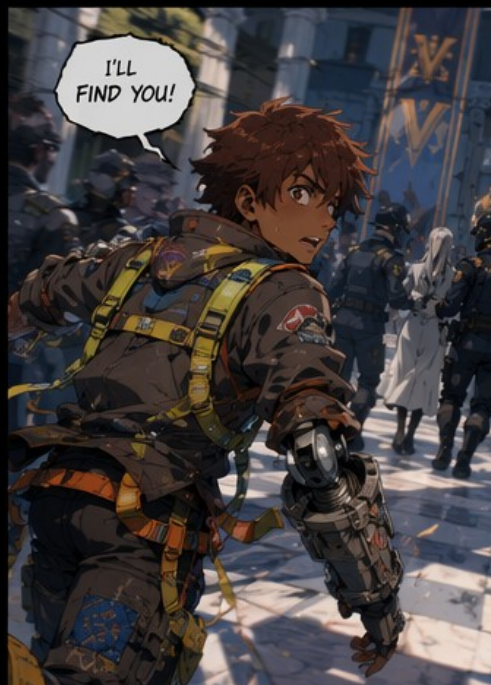


FOR SERVICE
ABOVE SELF.



LET ALL BEAR WITNESS.





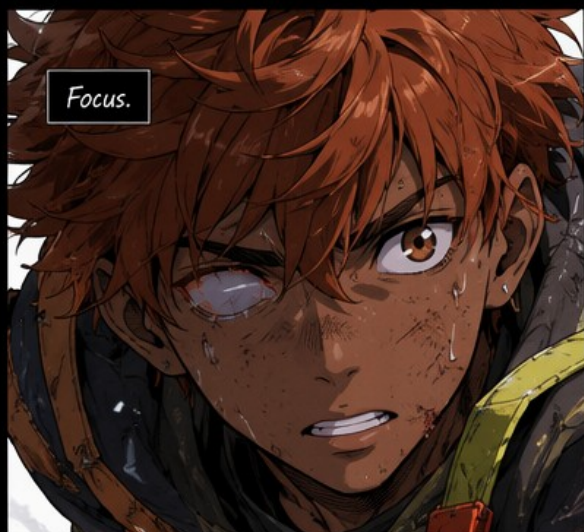


RENN.
Sixteen.

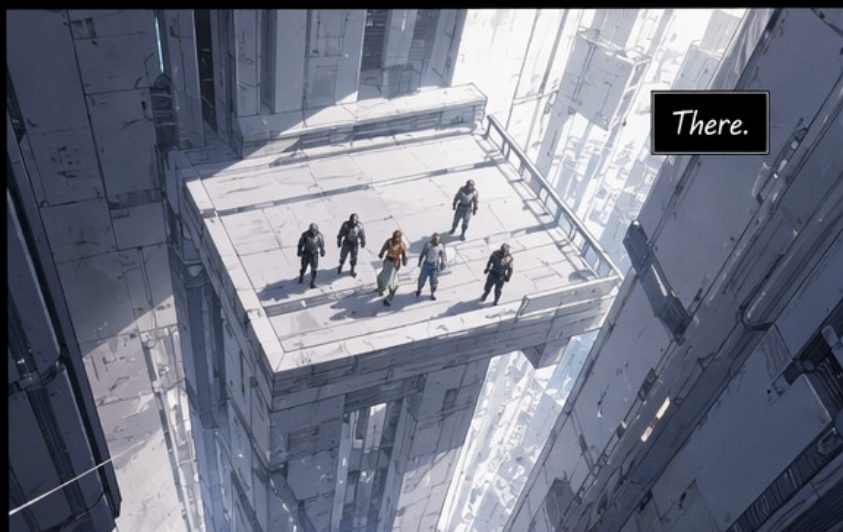
One good eye.
One dead arm.
And zero time.

They took
Sloane.

I'm taking
that back.



Focus.



There.



Don't think.
Don't breathe.
Just—

GO!!



Faster.
Closer.
Now.

I'M
ALREADY
THERE.

RENN

AGE: 16
TENSION-CRAFT CLIMBER
- RIGHT ARM: SCARRED.
NO TENSION.
- RIGHT EYE: BLIND.
- LEFT ARM: TENSION-GAUNTLET
SPOOL SYSTEM.

"YOU DON'T CLIMB
BECAUSE YOU'RE STRONG.
YOU CLIMB BECAUSE
YOU'RE STUPID."

OLD HABITS
DIE HARD.

SOMETIMES...
THEY DON'T DIE.

THEY JUST...
LET GO.

NOT EVERY FALL
BREAKS SOMETHING.

SOMETIMES IT'S JUST
A REMINDER.

YOU'RE NOT
INVINCIBLE.
NOT EVEN
A LITTLE.

SPIN

ZENITH PLATES.
VANGUARD
ENFORCEMENT
SECTOR 7.

RENN VARRO.
YOU ARE UNDER
ARREST FOR VIOLATION
OF THE TENSION-CRAFT
PROTOCOLS.

YEAH...
FIGURED.

ANY LAST
WORDS, CLIMBER?

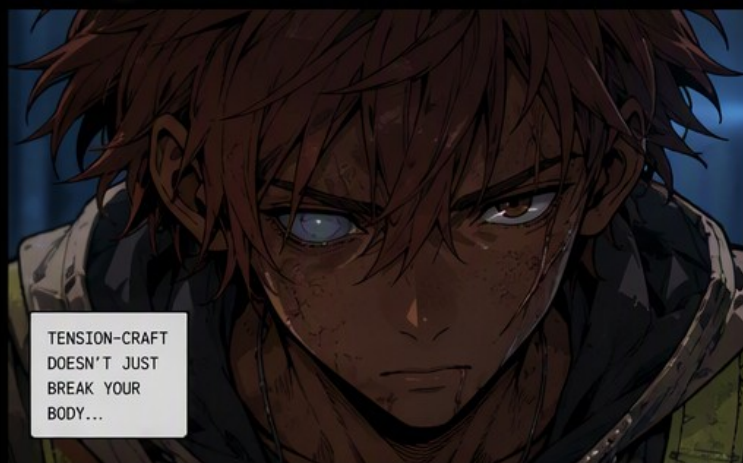
YEAH.
TELL MAE...
I'M SORRY.

THE PLATES
DON'T FORGIVE.
—
THEY ONLY
REMEMBER.

VANGUARD

TENSION IS
A GIFT.
—
BUT MISUSED—
IT BINDS YOU
INSTEAD.

VANGUARD HOLDING FACILITY
SECTOR 7B



TENSION-CRAFT
DOESN'T JUST
BREAK YOUR
BODY...



...IT REMEMBERS.



SPOOL LOCK
ENGAGED.

INMATE:
RENN.



SIXTEEN
YEARS OLD.

TENSION-CRAFT
INJURY.

RIGHT ARM
JAMMED.

RIGHT EYE
GONE.

WELCOME TO
YOUR NEW
TENSION.

CELL 17-B.
STANDARD
DETENTION.

NO WINDOWS.
NO CONTACT.
NO RECORD
OF YOUR
STAY.

KSSSHHH

FINAL.

THUD.

THE TENSION-FIELD
HUMS CONSTANT.
A SOFT SHIMMER
BEHIND THE AIR.

KEEPS YOU
STILL.
KEEPS YOU
SMALL.

KEEPS YOU
FORGETTABLE.

THEY TOOK
MY RIGHT ARM.
TOOK MY EYE.
TOOK MY
PLACE.

BUT THEY
DIDN'T TAKE
THE WIND.

THE LINE
STILL SINGS.
JUST
WAITING.

THE HIGHER
YOU CLIMB...
THE HARDER
YOU FALL.

...THE HIGHER
I'LL CLIMB.